

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

Technolust Rules



It was pretty bizarre to see the Taj Mahal floating down the Thames in London last week but even weirder was the sight of English yuppies sporting Apple's trendy iPhones! The reason that is so strange is that iPhones do not work anywhere else but in the US because of Apple's choice of AT&T as carrier partner as it is called in the States. AT&T is a telecom company which operates strictly within America. In effect, the iPhone is about as useful as a bowler hat would be to Monty Panesar. UK yuppies are not alone in their eccentric obsession. I saw at least three other iPhone flashers in Rome, a city where style often rules over substance. So what is the point of having a technological tool that you cannot use? It's called technolust, the irresistible desire to possess the latest trendy gadget, no matter what the cost or utility value. And it's a universal malady. I know people in Delhi who asked their American friends/relatives to queue up at the iPhone launch just so they could boast about having the gadget: Technolust has that effect on people.

SAURABH SINGH

There's a larger issue. The cellphone is no longer a mobile communicator, it's equally a style statement and extension of individual personality, as are most other gadgets these days. The result is excess. When the Blackberry came to India, it was elitist in price and consumer profile. Now that it's ubiquitous and affordable, most Blackberry users now need to sport a second cellphone equally expensive, just to reassert their individuality. What that means is that everyone is now so loaded with gadgets that it's become downright cumbersome. I know an industrialist who never leaves home without his Blackberry, a Nokia N75, a PDA, an iPod and a portable video player he uses on the journey from his Greater Kailash house to his factory in Gurgaon to watch movies. Even Roman legionnaires carried a lighter load.

Technolust is an obsession that clearly requires deep pockets, not just in terms of money but to carry all those gadgets around. Our kids are more prone to technolust. It's rare to see them without earphones from their iPod sticking in their ears. They no longer hear the sound of birds or traffic or even their parents asking them how their day went. They are too busy listening to the latest Bollywood item number while pecking away on their cellphones or Playstations. It's the men with their tech toys, however, who succumb more easily to technolust. For most, it's an adequate substitute for the physical kind.



SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"Aishwarya Rai is my favourite"

ACTOR SALMAN KHAN SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about his personality, films, his image and career

Q. I read that you figure in the list of the world's top ten handsome men.

A. My fans voted for that. Aamir Khan is number one this time.

Q. There is a lot of difference between the public perception of Salman Khan and the real Salman Khan.

A. I am the same person in reel and real life. I do not have a short temper and I have never fought with anyone. It is all a creation of media. Life is full of problems. I do not want to make it more depressing.

Q. Is there a conspiracy against you?

A. I do not have any rivalry with anybody. One is badshah, other is king and I am the joker. I laugh at people who laugh at me because they don't understand me. I like those who laugh with me.

Q. Most stars except Shatrughan Sinha support you.

A. Everyone has his or her own problem. I do not want anyone's help when I am in need. I'd rather sort out my problems myself.

SHAILESH RAVAL

Q. Who do you think is your competitor?

A. None. I don't have a hero. I compete with myself.

Q. Which is more important—acting or publicity?

A. I never act. I don't want to be number one.

Q. How did you start your film career?

A. I wanted to become a director. I was an assistant and a model but I weighed only 48 kg. I looked terrible in *Biwi Ho Toh Aisi*. Then I did *Maine Pyar Kiya* and I've never looked back.

Q. Which actor is your role model?

A. Dharmendraji.

Q. The best director.

A. Suraj Barjatya.

Q. And your favourite actress.

A. Hemaji is my all time favourite. Rani Mukherjee, Preity Zinta and Aishwarya Rai are also my favourites, and Priyanka Chopra, Lara Dutta and Katrina.

Q. Do you want to work with them?

A. I don't have a problem working with them. The producer and the director decide who I work with.

Q. What do you think about body building?

A. A good and handsome body is essential for an actor.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>

